Italy, Germany, Spain and elsewhere as a way – so they thought – to pre-empt a Soviet-style left-wing revolution.

But there was no reason to despair of the democratic middle path in the 1930s, and there is no reason to despair of it in the 2020s. The conservative suicide might be the result of groundless hysteria. As a system, democracy has already gone through several cycles of rapid changes and has so far always found a way to reinvent and reconstitute itself. For example, in the early 1930s Germany was not the only democracy hit by the financial crisis and the Great Depression. In the United States too unemployment reached 25 per cent, and average incomes for workers in many professions fell by more than 40 per cent between 1929 and 1933.[20] It was clear that the United States couldn't go on with business as usual.

Yet no Hitler took over in the United States, and no Lenin did, either. Instead, in 1933 Franklin Delano Roosevelt orchestrated the New Deal and made the United States the global 'arsenal of democracy'. US democracy after the Roosevelt era was significantly different from before – providing a much more robust social safety net for citizens – but it avoided any radical revolution.[21] Ultimately, even Roosevelt's conservative critics fell in line behind many of his programmes and achievements and did not dismantle the New Deal institutions when they returned to power in the 1950s.[22] The economic crisis of the early 1930s had such different outcomes in the United States and Germany because politics is never the product of only economic factors. The Weimar Republic didn't collapse just because of three years of high unemployment. Just as important, it was a new democracy, born in defeat, and lacking robust institutions and deep-rooted support.

When both conservatives and progressives resist the temptation of radical revolution, and stay loyal to democratic traditions and institutions, democracies prove themselves to be highly agile. Their self-correcting mechanisms enable them to ride the technological and economic waves better than more rigid regimes. Thus, those democracies that managed to survive the tumultuous 1960s – like the United States, Japan and Italy – adapted far more successfully to the computer revolution of the 1970s and 1980s than either the communist regimes of Eastern Europe or the fascist holdouts of southern Europe and South America.

The most important human skill for surviving the twenty-first century is likely to be flexibility, and democracies are more flexible than totalitarian